KEY DATA

Size ranking 31
Brightest stars Altarf (β) 3.5, Asellus Australis (δ) 3.9
Genitive Cancri
Abbreviation CnC
Highest in sky at 10pm February–March
Fully visible 90°N–57°S

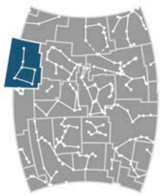


CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Acubens Alpha (α) Cancri
White main-sequence star and multiple star
4.3 ⟷ 188 light-years

Altarf Beta (β) Cancri
Orange giant and binary star
3.5 ⟷ 303 light-years

Asellus Borealis Gamma (γ) Cancri.
White subgiant
4.7 ⟷ 181 light-years

Asellus Australis Delta (δ) Cancri
Orange giant
3.9 ⟷ 131 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M44 (Beehive Cluster, Praesepe)
Open cluster

M67
Open cluster

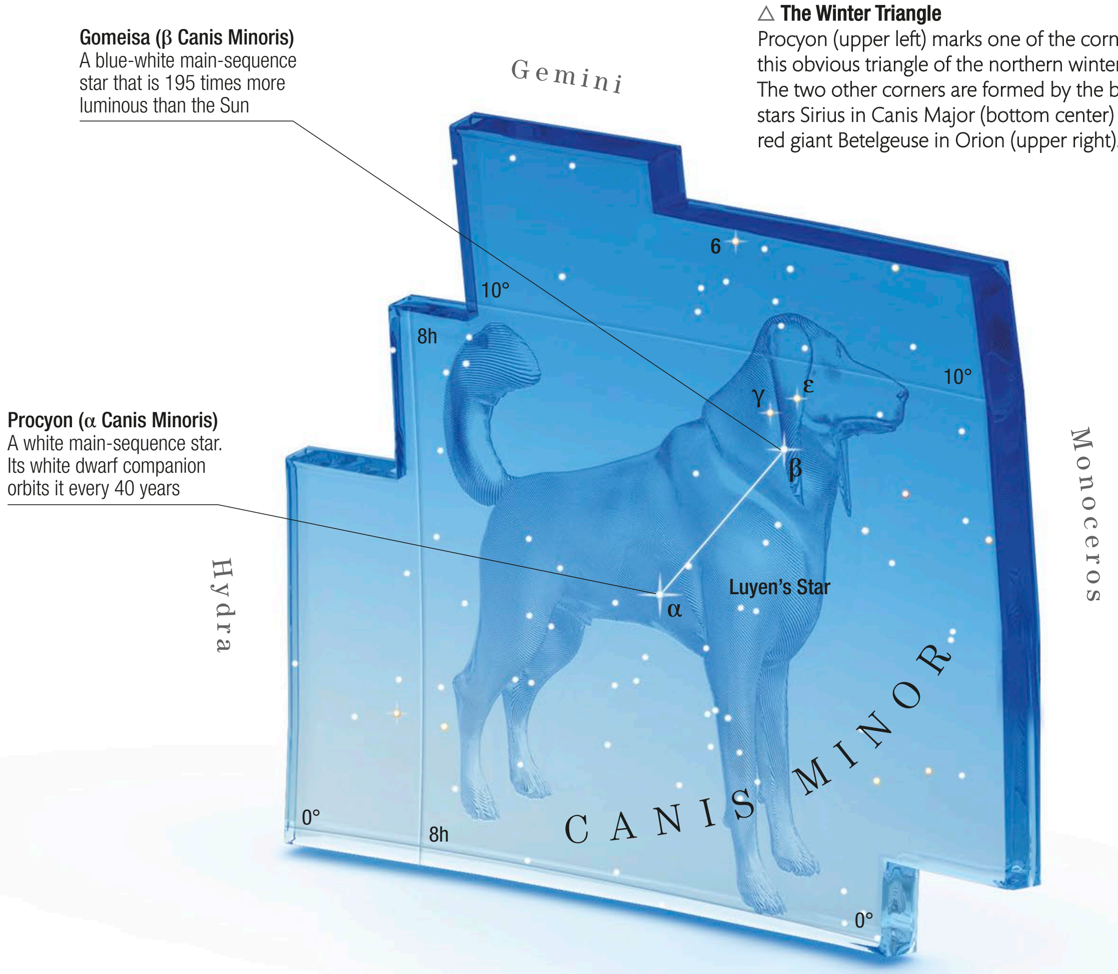
△ **M67**
The open star cluster M67 is about 5 billion years old, making it one of the oldest open clusters known. It consists of more than 100 stars with the same chemical composition as the Sun and red giants. Smaller, denser, and 2,600 light-years away, it is more distant than M44 (the Beehive Cluster) but also covers the width of a Full Moon. It can be seen using binoculars.

CANIS MINOR

THE LITTLE DOG

ONE OF THE ORIGINAL CONSTELLATIONS DESCRIBED BY THE ASTRONOMERS OF ANCIENT GREECE, CANIS MINOR IS SMALL BUT EASILY SPOTTED BECAUSE OF ITS BRILLIANT STAR PROCYON.

Canis Minor is the smaller of Orion's two hunting dogs. The little dog is drawn around the constellation's brightest stars Procyon and Gomeisa. Located almost on the celestial equator, the constellation has little of interest other than Procyon, the eighth brightest star in the night sky. Meaning "before the dog" in Greek, the star is so-named because in Mediterranean latitudes it rises shortly before the more brilliant Dog Star, Sirius (in Canis Major). Procyon and Sirius are about the same distance from Earth and their differing brightness therefore indicates a true difference in their luminosity. Procyon, like Sirius, is a binary with a white dwarf companion, Procyon B, visible with a very large telescope. Procyon also marks one corner of the Winter Triangle.



KEY DATA

Size ranking 71
Brightest stars Procyon (α) 0.4, Gomeisa (β) 2.9
Genitive Canis Minoris
Abbreviation CMi
Highest in sky at 10pm February
Fully visible 89°N–77°S


CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Procyon Alpha (α) Canis Minoris
White main-sequence star and binary star
0.4 ⟷ 11 light-years

Gomeisa Beta (β) Canis Minoris
Blue-white main-sequence star
2.9 ⟷ 162 light-years

△ **The Winter Triangle**
Procyon (upper left) marks one of the corners of this obvious triangle of the northern winter sky. The two other corners are formed by the brilliant stars Sirius in Canis Major (bottom center) and the red giant Betelgeuse in Orion (upper right).